

# TECHNOLOGY CONSULTING

IN THE GLOBAL COMMUNITY

## Final Consulting Report

Palau FIB

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**Carnegie Mellon University**



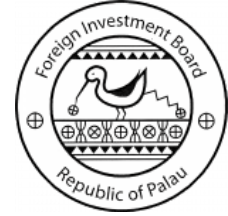


# Foreign Investment Board

## Executive Summary

Student Consultant, Joyce Lam

Community Partner, Raymond August



### I. About the Organization

The Foreign Investment Board (FIB) of Palau is responsible for overseeing the approval and monitoring of Foreign Investment Approval Certificates (FIACs). Its mission is

*to be a modern, efficient organization that drives sustainable high-value investments, boosts economic diversification, and safeguards local businesses for the benefit of Palau and its citizens.*

Currently, the FIB faces challenges with outdated, paper-based workflows and limited technical infrastructure. With few staff members possessing technical expertise, processes remain inefficient. These inefficiencies hinder timely processing of applications, increase the risk of error, and place additional strain on staff resources.

This consulting project focused on identifying opportunities for the FIB to modernize its processes through digital transformation. By leveraging cloud-based tools and lightweight automation, the FIB can reduce inefficiencies, improve transparency, and create a more sustainable workflow for handling FIAC applications and Quarterly Reports. Three primary goals were identified and addressed:

### II. Goal 1: Implement a Document Management System

The FIB's current reliance on physical filing cabinets makes retrieval and sharing of FIAC applications slow and prone to misfiling. A cloud-based Document Management System (DMS) was recommended to digitize FIAC records, improve accessibility, and reduce reliance on paper.

**Outputs/Outcomes:** Digitized records stored securely in Box, an online storage system, improved search and retrieval efficiency, and easier inter-agency sharing. Staff were trained on how to upload files to Box and on the file organization structure that defines how documents should be stored.

**Recommendation:** Conduct periodic spot checks of folders to ensure files are being uploaded correctly by office administrators and that the agreed-upon file organization and naming structures are being followed.

### III. Goal 2: Transition to Digital Submission for FIAC

Currently, applicants must deliver a flash drive and 15 paper copies to the FIB office, often omitting the digital version. A digital submission portal reduces this burden and ensures structured metadata is collected consistently.

**Outputs/Outcomes:** A secure submission portal for the public to submit FIAC applications integrated with the Box API and automatic organization of submissions into the correct FIB folders. This leads to reduced processing time of FIAC applications.

**Recommendation:** If users encounter confusion when navigating the portal, provide a step-by-step guide with screenshots or a short instructional video. This ensures applicants can easily follow the submission process and reduces the risk of incomplete or incorrect applications.

#### **IV. Goal 3: Automate Data Entry into a Centralized Database (Problem: Manual Transcription of Approved FIAC Data)**

Once a FIAC is approved, staff currently transcribe key fields into a master spreadsheet, a process that is tedious, error-prone, and unsustainable. Automation ensures data flows directly into a centralized tracking system.

**Outputs/Outcomes:** Google Forms (or a custom HTML form) integrated with Google Apps Script to auto-populate a master Google Sheet, ensuring immediate access to accurate data.

**Recommendation:** Future development should automate PDF-to-database extraction, removing redundancy while maintaining structured, centralized records. An OCR solution was being developed to extract metadata from submitted PDFs and automatically populate a CSV file, but time constraints made this unfeasible.

#### **V. Additional Recommendations**

Beyond the three core goals, it is recommended that the FIB continue investing in staff training, strengthen cybersecurity measures around its new digital systems, and establish clear compliance reporting standards. These additional steps will ensure that the organization's digital transition remains secure, sustainable, and aligned with its mission of supporting foreign investment in Palau.

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**About the Consultant**

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Joyce is a senior in Information Systems and  
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# Foreign Investment Board Proposal

Student Consultant, Joyce Lam

Global Community Partner, Raymond August

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## I. About the Organization

### Organization

The Foreign Investment Board (FIB) is a government agency established under the Executive branch of the Republic of Palau. Located in Koror, the FIB is responsible for approving and regulating foreign investment within the country. According to their five-year-plan, the mission of the FIB is

*to be a modern, efficient organization that drives sustainable high-value investments, boosts economic diversification, and safeguards local businesses for the benefit of Palau and its citizens.*

The Board's primary function is to evaluate incoming foreign investments and ensure that existing foreign-owned enterprises operate within a clearly defined legal framework. A dedicated task force supports the Board—comprising presidential appointees confirmed by the Senate—by reviewing applications and recommending actions, including the imposition of penalties for non-compliance.

Currently, the FIB faces significant operational challenges due to its heavy reliance on paper records, which are difficult to manage, track, and retrieve. As Palau's economy grows and regulatory demands increase, there is an urgent need for internal reforms that enhance efficiency, accessibility, and oversight within the agency.

### Facilities

The Foreign Investment Board (FIB) is located on the third floor of the One Stop Shop (OSS) Government Building in Koror, Palau. Completed in 2024, the OSS building also houses other key government agencies, including the Bureau of Tourism, the Bureau of Commerce, and the Environmental Quality Protection Board, among others.

The FIB's office space is modest but sufficient for its current staffing levels. It consists of an enclosed office, a conference room, a storage room used for filing cabinets, and an open workspace area. Desks are equipped with desktop computers and printers. While power supply is generally adequate, occasional island-wide outages do occur, temporarily disrupting operations. The office is air conditioned and well-ventilated.

Lighting in the office is sufficient, primarily relying on ceiling-mounted LED fixtures, with plentiful to natural light from large windows. Security is a concern: the building lacks controlled-access entry to offices and there is no dedicated physical security presence.

### Programs

The Foreign Investment Board (FIB) is responsible for reviewing, approving, and monitoring Foreign Investment Approval Certificate (FIAC) applications on a rolling basis. Each application is

carefully assessed for compliance with national investment laws and alignment with Palau's economic priorities. Once a decision is rendered, the application and all associated correspondence are filed as part of the applicant's official record.

In addition to initial application processing, the FIB oversees ongoing compliance by requiring FIAC holders to submit Quarterly Reports. These reports are submitted in paper format and are due by the following dates each year: January 31, April 30, July 31, October 31. Each Quarterly Report must include updates on: Employee headcount, Business license status, Tax compliance information

The FIB consolidates this data and produces an Annual Report summarizing the investment activity, compliance levels, and trends observed across FIAC holders. This Annual Report is submitted by the end of the fiscal year.

### **Staff**

The FIB consists of a Board of Directors and a few staff in charge of daily operations.

The Foreign Investment Board consists of seven presidential appointees who are approved by the Senate. Each member serves a three year term. Currently, only five seats are occupied.

On the Board of Directors is:

*Yvonne Ueda, Chairperson*

*Stephanie Nakamura, Vice Chairperson*

*Noah Secharraimul, Member*

*Ephraim Ngirachitei, Member*

*Cornelia Mason, Member*

The staff members in charge of daily operations include:

*Raymond August, Executive Director*

*Judith Dolongai W. Brodnansky, Administrative Officer*

*Christiaan Mitchell, Legal Counsel*

### **Technology Infrastructure**

|             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hardware    | Dell Optiplex 5000, 7020, 7050<br>Dell Inspiron 3910<br>HP ENVY TE01 (x2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Peripherals | ImageRUNNER 2525 - <b>Printer/Copier/Scanner</b><br>Canon ImageCLASS MF753Cdw - <b>Color Laser Printer/Scanner</b><br>Brother ADS-2200 - <b>Scanner</b><br>IBM Wheelwriter 1000 - <b>Typewriter</b><br>Brother FAX-575 - <b>Fax Machine</b><br>Royal 1630mc 16 Microcut x 2 - <b>Shredders</b> |

|  |                                                                                               |
|--|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  | Scanner imageRUNNER ADVANCE DX C3826i - <b>Scanner/Copier</b><br><i>Located in FIC office</i> |
|--|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## **Technology Management**

There is no technical contact for office-level tech issues, but there is a contact under the Information System Support Services Bureau who handles network-level issues for the Ministry of Finance: Conrad R. Ellechel. There are no antivirus or data backup protocols.

## **Technology Planning**

The FIB has made no attempt at technology planning or budgeting. New hardware is acquired on a need-basis.

## **Communication**

Internal document sharing at the FIB is primarily conducted via photocopies or email. Staff use personal email accounts to conduct official business. Previously, there has been a shared staff email account, but due to personnel changes the password and authentication of these accounts have been lost. To address this, the FIB is now starting to use a centralized government-issued email account: [fib@palaugov.org](mailto:fib@palaugov.org). This account ensures proper ownership, continuity, and authentication, reducing the risk of future access issues and enabling more consistent communication practices.

## **Information Management**

To submit an FIAC application, applicants must provide one physical copy of their full application, fifteen additional photocopies, and a digital copy on a USB drive. However, the digital copy is frequently omitted, requiring staff to manually scan the documents into a digital format.

Once received, the physical application packages are distributed to relevant government agencies for comment. These agencies return written feedback, which is then compiled for review.

Once a decision on the application has been made, the FIAC applications are officially filed. Currently, FIAC applications and Quarterly Reports are being (officially)? filed.

Sample FIAC Filing:

1. \*FIAC Certificate/\*Amendments
2. FIAC Application
3. \*Correspondence (Emails/Scans/Images)
4. Corporate Charter
5. Articles
6. Bylaws
7. Stock Affidavit
8. Shareholder Profiles (CV's, \*\*Police Clearance, \*\*Joint Account Info)
9. Lease Agreement

File access is restricted. Only management-level staff may open filing cabinets freely. The cabinets are locked. Other staff must sign files out to access them.

There are four file cabinets storing these documents. There are separate filing cabinets for active applications, inactive applications, and denied applications. Pending applications are not filed until a decision is made and until then are stored separately.

Quarterly reports are stored and not officially filed until the summary report of these reports is completed at the end of the fiscal year. After that, the staff file each quarterly report inside the appropriate file associated with the active application.

To support reporting to the President and National Congress, staff manually maintain an Excel sheet summarizing key data from active applications. Fields include: FIAC Number, Year Issued, Day Granted, Month, Expiration Date, Term Length, Grantee Name, Type of Permit, Form of Business, Scope, Services, Shareholders / Owners, Nationalities, Investment Amount, State(s) of Operation in Palau (PWState). This spreadsheet is essential for tracking high-level trends but is not linked to a database, making updates time-consuming and vulnerable to manual error.

## **II. Goal 1: Implement a Document Management System**

### **Motivation**

The Foreign Investment Board currently relies on a paper-based filing system to store the Foreign Investment Application Certificate (FIAC) records. However, with over two thousand applications and more adding to this collection every year, the current system is inefficient and prone to damage, misfiling, and misplacement of papers. When a request for a record is placed, staff must determine the company's assigned FIAC number from a manually maintained Excel spreadsheet and then retrieve the record from the filing cabinets. As the volume of records grows, this process becomes more difficult. Additionally, when the application is first submitted, it then needs to be sent to different agencies for comment. This requires the applicant to send in 15 additional copies of their application so the FIB can deliver physical copies to the agencies. This process wastes time, effort, and paper.

The reimplementation of a Document Management System (DMS) aims to: transition toward fully digital FIAC storage, improve efficiency and document accessibility, and reduce waste and long-term physical storage needs. A cloud-based DMS will let us scan, index, and secure every certificate, slashing retrieval times from minutes to seconds. It will also provide version control, audit trails, and role-based permissions—capabilities that paper simply cannot match. Over time, the system will eliminate the need for new physical storage, lower the Board's environmental footprint, and ensure business continuity in case of fire or flood.

### **Outcomes**

After researching and analyzing multiple document management solutions, I interviewed staff and reviewed user requirements. Based on this analysis, I presented the options to the FIB, recommending Box, a cloud storage system, as the best solution for their digital filing needs. I developed a standardized folder and naming convention to ensure consistent document filing. Each FIAC record is stored in its own dedicated folder, labeled with both the FIAC number and company name, and subdivided into categories (Application, Correspondence, Agency Comments, Renewal, etc.). Then, I trained administrative officers on scanning and uploading FIAC



applications directly to Box, ensuring they understood indexing practices, access controls, and basic troubleshooting.

### **Recommendations**

Going forward, the staff should continue to scan new and existing applications into the designated Box folders, with priority being given to frequently requested files.

To maintain consistency and ensure the quality of records is being preserved, quarterly audits should verify that files follow the standardized structure and that permissions remain appropriate.

## **III. Goal 2: Transition to Digital Submission for FIAC**

Currently applicants are required to submit their FIAC application in-person to the FIB office on a flashdrive along with 15 additional paper copies to the FIB office; however, the digital copy is often omitted, undermining the efficiency gained from the new document management system implemented. Therefore, the next major objective is to streamline the application and reporting process by transitioning from physical to digital submission for both FIAC applications and Quarterly Reports.

The goal is to reduce this paper-based workload by allowing applicants to complete and submit forms online through a secure web portal. This would include uploading required attachments and automatically populating the database with structured metadata (e.g., business name, form of business, investment scope). On the backend, these submissions would be automatically organized into the appropriate file structure, aligned with the digital DMS. Quarterly Reports would also be submitted digitally, reducing delays and improving the timeliness of aggregated reports for Congress.

### **Outcomes**

A submission portal—originally created in 2016—was reinstated and updated to ensure compatibility with the current Box API. The improved portal now functions reliably, enabling applicants to submit FIAC applications online with attachments that are automatically organized into the appropriate DMS folders. This upgrade removes the dependency on physical submissions, shortens processing times, and aligns digital submissions with current document management workflows.

### **Recommendations**

At present, there is no separate submission form for Quarterly Reports. Ideally, the system should include a dedicated, secure form for Quarterly Report submissions that incorporates identity verification to confirm the applicant is submitting on behalf of their registered company. Upon successful verification, the submission should be automatically routed to the corresponding Box folder within the FIB account. Integrating this process into the existing portal would centralize all digital submissions, improve data integrity, and reduce manual intervention. Additionally, training materials and user support should be provided to ensure smooth adoption by applicants and staff.

## **IV. Goal 3: Automate Data Entry into a Centralized Database (Problem: Manual Transcription of Approved FIAC Data)**

Currently, after a Foreign Investment Approval Certificate (FIAC) is approved, staff manually transcribe select fields into a master spreadsheet to track key details. This process is tedious, error-prone, and unsustainable as the volume of FIACs grows.

This goal proposes automating the transfer of structured data from the digital submission form directly into a centralized database or spreadsheet. This will reduce errors, improve turnaround time for reporting, and free up staff time for more critical tasks like compliance tracking and report writing.

Given the limited technical background of FIB staff, the need for cloud access, and the existing use of Gmail infrastructure, Google Sheets is the more appropriate tool for this use case. It allows direct integration with Google Forms or custom HTML forms using Google Apps Script to automate data entry. This reduces the need for manual handling and ensures data is instantly centralized and accessible for internal tracking or reporting.

### **Outcomes**

A Google Form was created that mirrors the FIAC application questions from the previous page. Applicants are required to complete and submit this form before continuing, ensuring that responses are captured digitally and centralized in a spreadsheet. This step provides a structured format for collecting application data, but it duplicates the information already contained in the uploaded PDF submissions.

### **Recommendations**

The current Google Form process is repetitive and unnecessarily burdensome for applicants. To improve the portal, future development should focus on automating the extraction of structured data directly from the submitted PDFs (or the digital submission form itself) into a spreadsheet or database. This will eliminate duplicate work for applicants, reduce redundancy, and streamline internal data handling. Leveraging tools such as Google Apps Script, OCR-based parsing, or custom form-to-database integrations would ensure that FIAC application data flows automatically into the centralized tracking system without requiring applicants to re-enter the same information.

Github Portal: <https://github.com/jzlam/fib-palau.git>